Rwanda Non-Government Organization

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IBE RWANDA CHAPTER

GECO STRATEGIC PLAN FOR 2024-2030

PART ONE:

Purpose of this Strategic Plan and intended users

A Strategic Plan is a high level vision document describing how a particular organisation intends to move towards a future goal, an improved state of affairs. It is roadmap which serves to guide the planning of activities; a set of instructions of how best to deliver the mission and objectives of the organisation. In the case of Global Epileptic Connection (GECO) its purpose is to work to improve the lives of persons with epilepsy (PWE) and other mental disabilities in Rwanda and to promote the full inclusion into development programmes and services so that persons with epilepsy and other mental disabilities may participate fully in all areas of life. Over the next five years (2024 -2029) GECO will work towards this goal. The overall vision and priorities reflected in this Strategic Plan will be translated once it is adopted, into more detailed, short term operational plans with budgets. In turn these will be reviewed by staff, as they are implemented and revised annually in light of evolving context and the changes achieved.

The GECO Strategic Plan is a public document that sets out to explain the history, vision and objectives of this Organization Global Epileptic Connection, which was established by law and linked to the Ministry of Health (MoH) and Rwanda Biomedical Center (RBC). Its main users will be staff required to execute the vision and ambition of other internal stakeholders (Board members, and persons with epilepsy who are the main intended beneficiaries). The Strategic Plan should also serve as a tool to inform Government of Rwanda, development partners and potential donors to GECO of the organisation's vision, focus and the strategies chosen to deliver benefit in terms of improvements in the lives of persons with epilepsy and other mental disabilities, their families and carers.

WHAT IS GLOBAL EPILEPTIC CONNECTION "GECO" :

Global Epilepsy Connection (GECO) is a Rwandan national non-governmental organization (NGO) founded on October 29, 2010. Born from the compassionate efforts of concerned parents, individuals with epilepsy, medical professionals, and other stakeholders, GECO emerged to address the significant unmet needs of people with epilepsy and other mental health conditions. Initially operating in Rubavu District, Western Province, GECO has expanded its reach nationwide, working to improve the lives of those affected through integrated approaches encompassing health, socio-economic empowerment, and advocacy for legislative change.

GECO Vision:

Our Vision is to see a country where all individuals with epilepsy and other mental disabilities enjoy full rights, social inclusion, well-being, and self-reliance, contributing to a thriving and sustainable holistic development.

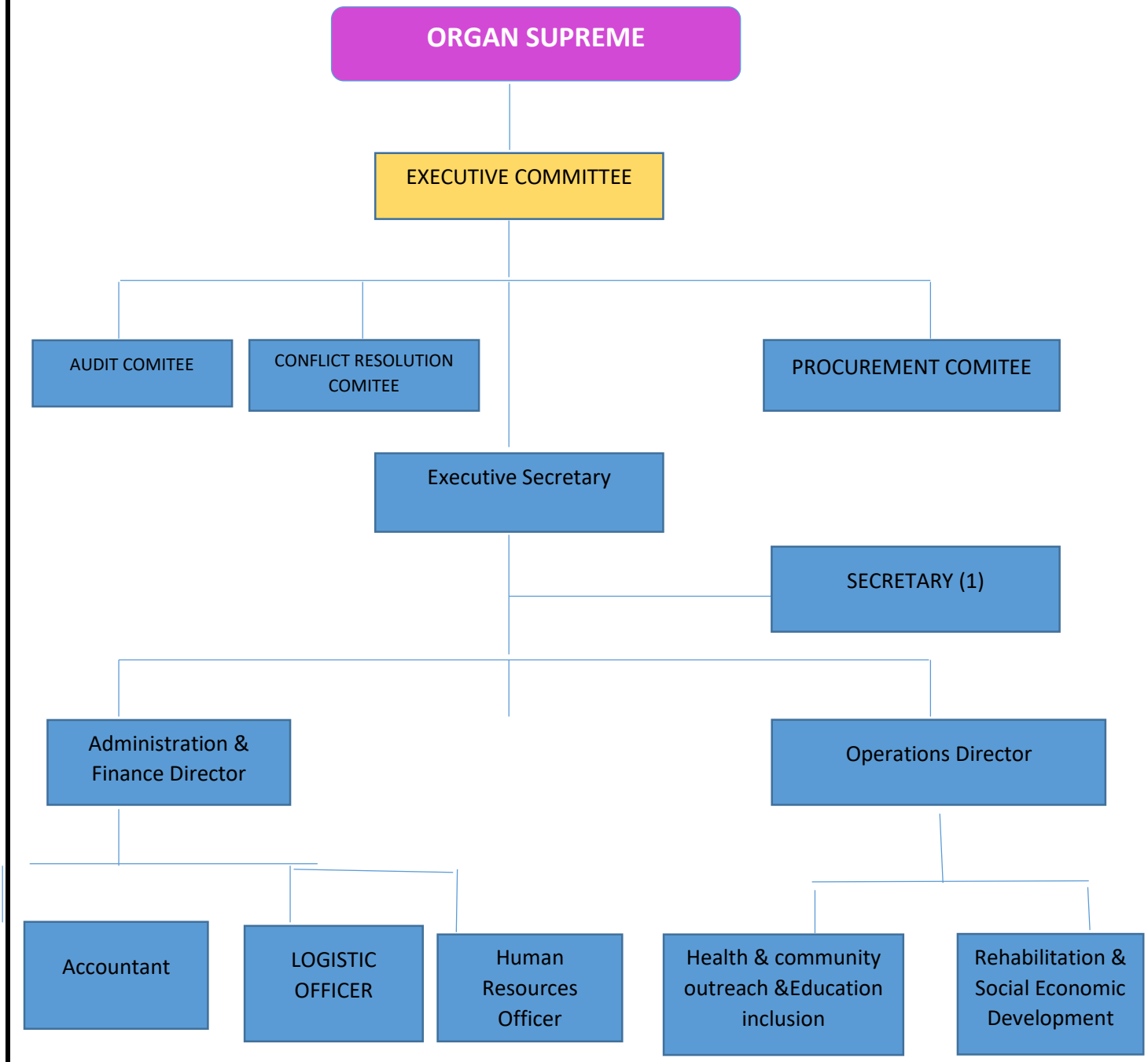
GECO Mission

Our mission is to cultivate a sense of belonging within the community while empowering individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities through professional healthcare, socio-economic initiatives, and advocacy.

GECO CORE VALUES :

- **Respect:** We treat everyone with dignity, valuing their contributions and building trust.
- **Inclusion:** We create welcoming environments where everyone feels valued and can fully participate.
- **Accountability:** We ensure participation, evaluation, transparency, and feedback in all our actions.
- **Equity:** We guarantee fair treatment and opportunity for all, actively eliminating barriers to participation.
- **Impact:** We strive for measurable, beneficial change.

ORGANIZATIONAL STRUCTURE OF GLOBAL EPILEPTIC CONNECTION (GECO)



WHAT IS EPILEPSY

Epilepsy remains a significant public health concern in Rwanda, affecting individuals of all ages and backgrounds. Despite advances in healthcare, stigma and misconceptions surrounding epilepsy persist, leading to social exclusion and barriers to treatment. People with epilepsy often face discrimination in education, employment, and social interactions, which impacts their overall quality of life.

Epilepsy, though not as commonly known or prioritized as some other health conditions, represents a significant public health challenge in Rwanda. Unlike infectious diseases or chronic illnesses that may receive more widespread attention, epilepsy often remains misunderstood, stigmatized, and overlooked in public health agendas. This lack of awareness and prioritization exacerbates the challenges faced by individuals living with epilepsy and their families.

Prevalence and Impact:

Epilepsy affects approximately 49 out of every 1,000 individuals in Rwanda, totaling more than 600,000 people and making it one of the most prevalent neurological disorders in the country. Despite its relatively high prevalence, misconceptions about epilepsy persist, leading to social stigma, discrimination, and barriers to treatment. Unlike diseases with more visible symptoms or higher mortality rates, epilepsy's invisible nature and unpredictable seizures often contribute to its marginalization within healthcare systems and communities.

Social and Economic Burden:

Beyond its medical implications, epilepsy imposes significant social and economic burdens on individuals, families, and society at large. The stigma associated with epilepsy can result in social exclusion, limited educational and employment opportunities, and strained family relationships. These psychosocial challenges further exacerbate the economic burden, as people with epilepsy may face higher healthcare costs and reduced earning potential.

Access to Healthcare:

Access to quality healthcare remains a critical issue for people with epilepsy in Rwanda. Unlike diseases with dedicated national programs or extensive resources, epilepsy care often relies on fragmented services within primary healthcare settings. Limited availability of antiepileptic drugs (AEDs), lack of health insurance for some epileptic families due to poverty, insufficient training of healthcare providers in epilepsy management, and inadequate public awareness contribute to suboptimal treatment outcomes and disparities in care across regions.

Comparison with Other Diseases:

In comparison to diseases like malaria, HIV/AIDS, or tuberculosis, which receive considerable attention and resources globally and nationally, epilepsy remains underfunded and under-prioritized. The chronic nature of epilepsy requires long-term management and support, yet funding and infrastructure for epilepsy services often lag behind those allocated to infectious diseases or acute conditions.

Advocacy and Awareness:

Addressing epilepsy in Rwanda requires heightened advocacy efforts to raise awareness, reduce stigma, and advocate for policy reforms. Unlike diseases with well-established advocacy networks and international support, epilepsy advocacy in Rwanda relies on grassroots efforts, collaboration with NGOs, and partnerships with government agencies to amplify its visibility and impact.

While epilepsy may not receive the same level of attention as other diseases, its impact on individuals, families, and communities underscores the urgency of addressing it within Rwanda's healthcare landscape. By prioritizing epilepsy awareness, advocacy, and comprehensive care, Rwanda Organization for Epilepsy (ROE) aims to elevate epilepsy on the national health agenda, improve treatment outcomes, and enhance the quality of life for individuals living with epilepsy across the country.

PART TWO:

STRATEGIC PLAN FOR RWANDA ORGANISATION FOR EPILEPSY "GECO" 2024-2030

I. Executive Summary:

This strategic plan outlines Global Epileptic Connection's (GECO) vision for a nation where individuals with epilepsy and other mental disabilities thrive, enjoying full rights, social inclusion, and self-reliance. Over the next seven years (2024-2030), GECO will focus on achieving its mission of fostering belonging and empowerment through three key strategic pillars: **professional healthcare access**, **socio-economic empowerment**, **and impactful advocacy**. Guided by our core values of respect, inclusion, accountability, equity, and impact, this plan details specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound (SMART) goals and objectives to ensure sustainable and measurable progress.

Key Strategic Pillars:

Enhanced Healthcare Access: This pillar focuses on increasing access to quality, affordable, and culturally sensitive healthcare services for individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities. Specific initiatives include expanding partnerships with healthcare providers, developing accessible educational resources, and advocating for policy changes that improve healthcare coverage.

Socio-Economic Empowerment: This pillar aims to improve the economic independence and social participation of individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities. Strategies include developing vocational training programs, promoting entrepreneurship, and advocating for inclusive employment policies.

Effective Advocacy: This pillar will focus on raising awareness about epilepsy and mental disabilities, influencing policy changes at local and national levels, and challenging societal

stigma. Activities include public awareness campaigns, lobbying efforts, and collaborations with key stakeholders.

Measurable Outcomes: The plan outlines specific, measurable indicators to track progress across all three pillars, including increased access to healthcare services, improved employment rates, reduced stigma, and strengthened policy environments. Regular monitoring and evaluation will ensure accountability and allow for adaptive management to maximize impact.

Resource Allocation: The plan details a comprehensive resource allocation strategy, outlining the financial and human resources required to achieve the stated goals. This includes securing funding, building partnerships, and developing a skilled workforce.

This strategic plan represents a roadmap for GECO to achieve significant and lasting positive change in the lives of individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities. By focusing on these three pillars and adhering to our core values, GECO is confident in its ability to create a more inclusive and equitable society for all.

II. Situation Analysis:

This SWOT analysis assesses Global Epileptic Connection's (GECO) internal strengths and weaknesses, and external opportunities and threats, to inform the development of its strategic plan focused on Enhanced Healthcare Access, Socio-Economic Empowerment, and Effective Advocacy .

2.1. Strengths:

- ✓ **Strong Mission and Vision:** GECO's clearly defined mission and vision provide a strong foundation and guide for its activities, aligning efforts and attracting support

- ✓ **Established NGO in Rwanda:** Existing local presence and networks provide a head start in understanding the context and building relationships with stakeholders.

- ✓ **Commitment to Core Values**: The emphasis on respect, inclusion, accountability, equity, and impact fosters a positive organizational culture and builds trust with beneficiaries and partners.

- ✓ **Experienced Team :** A dedicated and knowledgeable team is crucial for effective program implementation and advocacy.

- ✓ **Existing Programs :** Pre-existing programs provide a base to build upon and demonstrate existing capacity.

2.2. Weaknesses:

- ✓ **Limited Resources :** NGOs often face funding constraints, limiting the scale and scope of their programs.

- ✓ **Capacity Building Needs**: Strengthening staff skills in specific areas (e.g., project management, fundraising, advocacy) may be necessary.

- ✓ **Dependency on External Funding** : Reliance on external funding can create instability and vulnerability to changes in donor priorities. This requires a diversification strategy.

- ✓ **Reaching Remote Areas :** Reaching marginalized populations in remote areas of Rwanda may pose logistical and accessibility challenges

- ✓ **Lack of widespread awareness :** Limited public awareness of GECO's work could hinder its impact and ability to attract support.

2.3. Opportunities:

- ✓ **Government Support for Disability Inclusion**: Leveraging government initiatives and policies aimed at improving the lives of people with disabilities.

- ✓ **Growing Awareness of Mental Health:** Increasing societal awareness of mental health issues, creating an environment more receptive to GECO's work.

- ✓ **Partnerships with International Organizations**: Collaborating with international NGOs and development agencies to expand resources and expertise.

- ✓ **Technological Advancements:** Utilizing technology to improve access to healthcare and services.

- ✓ **Corporate Social Responsibility:** Engaging with Rwandan businesses for funding and volunteer support through RSSB insurance initiatives.

2.4. Threats:

- ✓ **Funding Competition:** Intense competition for funding among NGOs operating in Rwanda.
- ✓ **Stigma and Discrimination:** Persistent societal stigma and discrimination against people with epilepsy and mental disabilities can hinder program effectiveness.

- ✓ **Lack of Healthcare Materials:** The equipment necessary for the diagnosis and treatment of epilepsy and other mental disorders is not enough , sometimes you have to go to Kigali to access these devices.

Note: This SWOT analysis provides a framework. To make it truly effective, GECO needs to fill in the specifics for each point, quantify its strengths and weaknesses (e.g., using data on budget, staff expertise, program reach), and prioritize the opportunities and threats based on their likelihood and impact. This detailed analysis will help GECO formulate a robust and targeted strategic plan.

III. Strategic Goals:

3.1. Healthcare Integration:

3.1.1. Goal 1: **Enhanced Healthcare Access:** Increase the availability and accessibility of quality diagnostic services, medication, and treatment for epilepsy and other mental disabilities across target communities in Rwanda, focusing on reducing geographical and financial barriers. This includes training healthcare professionals and establishing partnerships with existing healthcare facilities.

3.1.2 Goal 2: **Strengthen Community-Based Healthcare Support Systems:** Develop and implement sustainable community-based healthcare models, including outreach programs, mobile clinics, and home-based care, to ensure continuous support and monitoring for individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities. This includes empowering community health workers..

3.2. Social-Economic Empowerment:

3.2.1. Goal 3: **Social-Economic Empowerment:** Create and implement income-generating activities and skills training programs tailored to the needs and abilities of individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities, improving their economic independence and social standing. This could include vocational training, micro-finance initiatives, and entrepreneurship support. In this Framework ensuring that at least 60% of participants secure employment or start their own businesses within one year of completion by 2030.

3. 3. Reduced Stigma and Improved Social Inclusion:

3.3.1. Goal 4: Implement comprehensive public awareness campaigns to challenge societal stigma and misconceptions surrounding epilepsy and mental disabilities, promoting understanding and acceptance within communities. This includes working with schools, religious leaders, and media outlets.

3.3.2. Goal 5 Advocate for Policy and Legislative Changes: Actively lobby and advocate for policy and legislative changes at national and local levels that ensure the rights and protection of individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities, including access to education, employment, and healthcare. This involves building relationships with government officials and policymakers.

3. 4. Strengthened collaboration and Capacity Building:

3.4.1. Goal 6 : Strengthen Organizational Capacity and Sustainability: Enhance GECO's organizational capacity through improved governance, financial management, staff development, and resource mobilization to ensure the long-term sustainability of its programs and impact. This includes securing diverse funding streams and building strong partnerships.

3.3.2. Goal 7: Build a coalition of stakeholders, including government agencies, NGOs, and community leaders, to promote a unified message and action plan for the rights and inclusion of individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities, achieving formal recognition by key stakeholders by 2026.

3.5. Research and Data Collection:

3.5.1. Goal 8: Conduct research to gather evidence on prevalence and impact of epilepsy and related mental health issues in Rwanda and to use data to inform policy-making, program development, and resource allocation.

3.6. Monitoring and Evaluation:

3.6.1. Goal 9: Implement a robust monitoring and evaluation framework for all programs to measure their effectiveness and impact, ensuring that data is collected and analysed annually

to inform program adjustments, with a comprehensive report presented to stakeholders each year starting in 2024.

IV. Strategic Objectives:

This strategic plan lays a solid foundation for GECO's growth and impact from 2024 through 2030. We are committed to forging a path towards a more inclusive society where individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities can thrive and participate fully in community life. By focusing on advocacy, healthcare integration, community empowerment, capacity building, and research, GECO can effectively meet its mission and fulfil its vision for a better Rwanda.

Here are SMART strategic objectives based on your provided strategic goals. Remember that SMART stands for Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.

1. Enhanced Healthcare Access:

Objective 1.1.1: By 2028, increase the number of individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities receiving diagnostic services by 50% in three target districts (specify districts), as measured by documented patient records.

Objective 1.1.2 : By 2026, train 30 healthcare professionals (specify type of professionals) in the diagnosis and management of epilepsy and mental disabilities, measured by successful completion certificates.

Objective 1.1.3 : Establish partnerships with at least 5 existing healthcare facilities (specify type of facilities) in target areas by 2025, measured by signed partnership agreements.

Objective 1.2.1 : Implement 2 mobile clinic outreach programs reaching at least 500 individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities annually by 2027, measured by attendance records.

Objective 1.2.2 : Train and deploy 20 community health workers (CHWs) in each target district by 2027, measured by completion of training and deployment records, providing ongoing support through supervision visits.

2. Social-Economic Empowerment:

Objective 2.1.1 : By 2030, achieve a 60% employment rate or successful business start-up rate among participants completing GECO's vocational training and micro-finance programs, measured by post-program surveys and follow-up data.

Objective 2.1.2 : Develop and implement 3 different income-generating programs (specify programs) by 2027, measured by the number of participants enrolled in each program.

3. Reduced Stigma and Improved Social Inclusion:

Objective 3.1.1 : Conduct at least 4 public awareness campaigns reaching a minimum of 10,000 people in target communities by 2028, measured by campaign reach data (e.g., media impressions, attendance at events).

Objective 3.1.2 : Secure partnerships with 2 major media outlets and 5 schools in target communities by 2026 to disseminate anti-stigma messages, measured by signed agreements and media coverage data.

Objective 3.2.1 : Submit at least 2 policy recommendations to the Rwandan government related to the rights of individuals with epilepsy and mental disabilities by 2027, measured by submission confirmation documentation.

Objective 3.2.2 : Secure a meeting with at least 3 key policymakers to discuss proposed legislation by 2026, measured by meeting confirmations and minutes.

4. Strengthened Collaboration and Capacity Building:

Objective 4.1.1: Increase GECO's annual budget by 30% by 2028 through diversified funding streams (specify sources), measured by financial reports.

Objective 4.1.2 : Develop and implement a staff training program on financial management and program implementation by 2025, with 100% staff participation, measured by training attendance records and post-training evaluations.

Objective 4.2.1 : Establish a formal coalition with at least 5 key stakeholders (specify stakeholders) by 2026, measured by signed memoranda of understanding (MOUs).

5. Research and Data Collection:

Objective 5.1.1: Collaborate with local and international universities, health institutions, and relevant NGOs to strengthen research capacity and enhance data collection methods on epilepsy and mental health in Rwanda.

Objective 5.1.2: Implement large-scale surveys to gather quantitative and qualitative data on the prevalence of epilepsy and associated mental health disorders among diverse populations in Rwanda and Analyse collected data to identify key trends and insights, which will be used to advocate for policy changes and improved resource allocation at local, national, and government levels

Objective 5.1.3: Implement a system for ongoing data collection and research, ensuring continuous monitoring of trends and changes in the prevalence of epilepsy and related mental health issues over time and Identify and pursue funding opportunities from governmental, academic, and international organizations to support research initiatives and ensure sustainability

6. Monitoring and Evaluation:

Objective 5.1.1 : Develop and implement a comprehensive monitoring and evaluation plan by 2025, which includes data collection instruments and analysis protocols, documented in a formal plan.

Objective 5.1.2 : Submit an annual progress report to stakeholders, including key performance indicators (KPIs), starting in 2025, measured by submission records and stakeholder feedback.

Conclusion

These strategic goals, when implemented, will help GECO achieve its long-term vision and mission while aligning with core values such as respect, inclusion, accountability, equity, and impact. Each goal is designed to provide measurable outcomes, ensuring your organization can track its progress effectively.

Done at Rubavu on 24/12/2024

GECO Legal Representative
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